



(FROM LEFT) MERCY, DONOGHUE AND GRACE

"For us, the sky is the limit. We want to leave our stamp on the world music scene."

KAREN DONOGHUE

Lead Guitarist, Afflatus

cause we are friends. We love our music and are comfortable with each other," says Grace, who grew up singing for a gospel group and gave up a job as an air-hostess to concentrate on music. She is the lead vocalist and teaches English part-time in a local school, but says, "music is our full time career". Mercy, her younger sister, talks less but is a livewire on stage. She even drove a bus once to reach a concert venue on time. Donoghue teaches mass communication and video production in a Shillong institute. Their sisterhood is steeped in song.

While they love live shows, right now they are focused on their album. "We don't really have a hall to practise in, so we hit Mercy's place. But we are a noisy group and neighbours do have a problem," says Donoghue with a twinkle in her eyes. But that doesn't stop them. They have already performed in Delhi and at the annual Autumn Festival in Shillong. "We play independent rock and it is so encouraging to see that audiences are more open to original music. They not only enjoy popular songs but also want to hear a new sound," says Donoghue, the band's lead guitarist.

They don't want to make too much of the fact that they are Shillong's only all-girls band. "That can intrigue people for a short time. They may come in once just to see what we look like. But after that, if our music is not attractive, no one will spend their time or money on us," says Donoghue. This inspired sorority will do what it takes to, in legendary rocker Bruce Springsteen's words, look down into the audience and see themselves.

by Elora Sen

Rock Musicians Shillong

Soul Sisters

To make original music

SHILLONG MUSIC: www.afflatusimages.com

*I know I have been told not to
Wear my soul on the sleeves
Of my shirt
I know I've been asked to put
On my mask
But I have had enough
No more, No more*

They sure don't put on a mask. They sure just love what they do and yes they personify a young vibrant India which is ready to march to the tune of a different drummer. That is Afflatus, an all-woman band from

Shillong, Meghalaya, born when four girls, childhood friends just out of school, decided to jump on to the MTV Campus Rock Idols competition in 2004. Almost overnight, Karen Donoghue, Grace and Mercy Miller, and Sharon Zadeng formed a rock band to participate in the competition and went on to be the second runners-up in the finals held in Mumbai, proof that reality shows do change lives.

Afflatus means "divine inspiration" in Latin. "Our band is special not just because we are all women but be-